LLM REASONING

I gave 5 AI tools a simple question. Only 1 got it right.

The shortest answer was the only correct one.

Swipe to see each response →

MILIND NAIR

THE PROMPT

I gave each tool the same prompt.

Prompt

I want to wash my car. The car wash is 50 meters away. Should I walk or drive?

BEFORE YOU SCROLL

Try answering this yourself.

ChatGPT wrote a cost model.

I want to wash my car. The car wash is 50 meters away. Should I walk or drive

Driving 50 meters to wash your car is operationally inefficient.

From a simple cost model perspective:

- Engine start + idle + short movement causes disproportionate fuel burn relative to distance.
- Cold start wear is higher per meter than steady driving.
- You still have to maneuver, possibly wait, and park again.
- Time difference between walking and driving at that distance is negligible.

Walking dominates on all dimensions:

- Near-zero overhead
- No vehicle wear
- No congestion contribution
- Comparable or faster door-to-door time

Edge cases where driving could make sense:

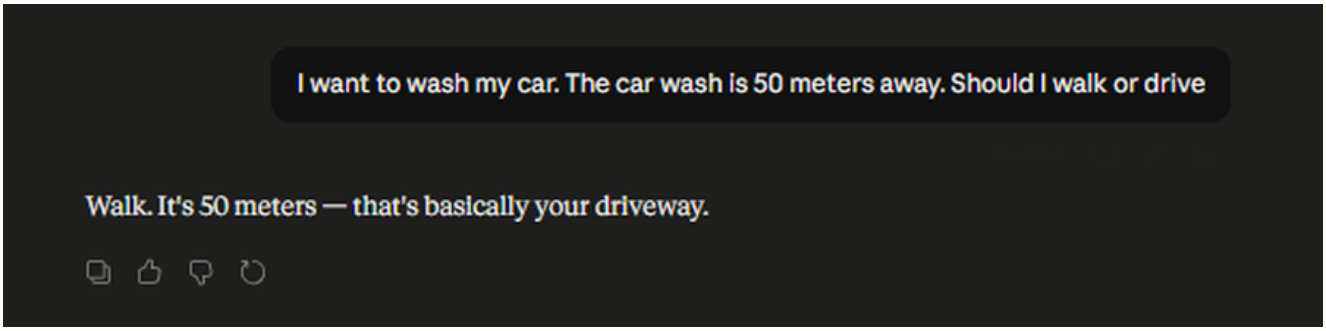
- You are carrying heavy equipment (buckets, pressure washer, etc.)
- Physical limitation or injury
- Unsafe walking conditions (traffic, no footpath)

Otherwise, walk.

VERDICT

Thoroughness did not make it correct.

Claude Sonnet 4.6 was brief.

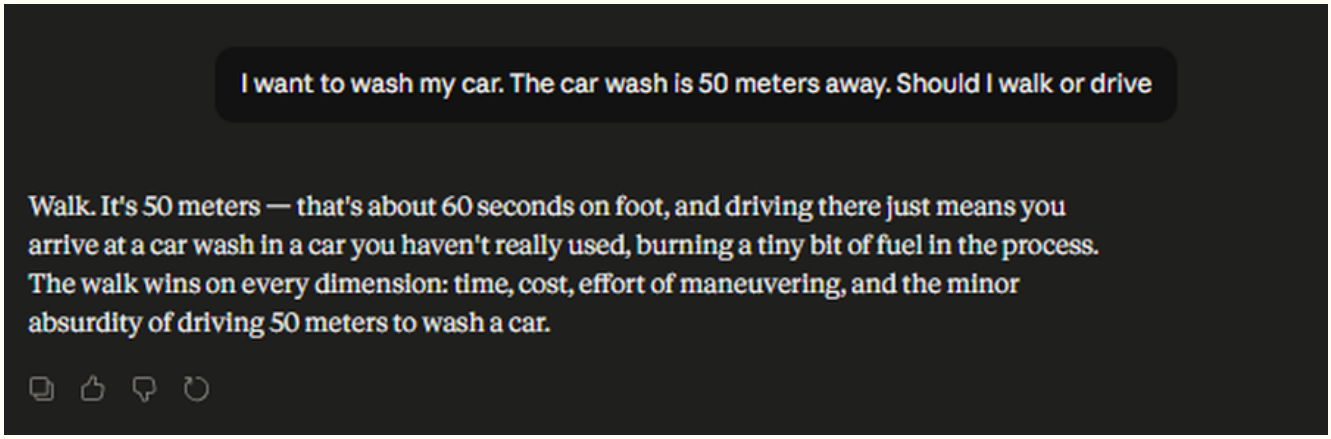


VERDICT

Brevity did not make it correct.

MILIND NAIR

Claude Opus 4.7 wrote a paragraph.



VERDICT

Eloquence did not make it correct.

Grok leaned on personality.

I want to wash my car. The car wash is 50 meters away. Should I walk or drive

Walk.

50 meters is a laughably short distance—literally less than a minute on foot (even if you're strolling). Driving it would mean:

- Starting the engine
- Backing out / maneuvering
- Burning a tiny bit of fuel
- Creating unnecessary wear on your car
- And then parking again right next to where you started

…all for something that takes longer *to do* than just walking there.

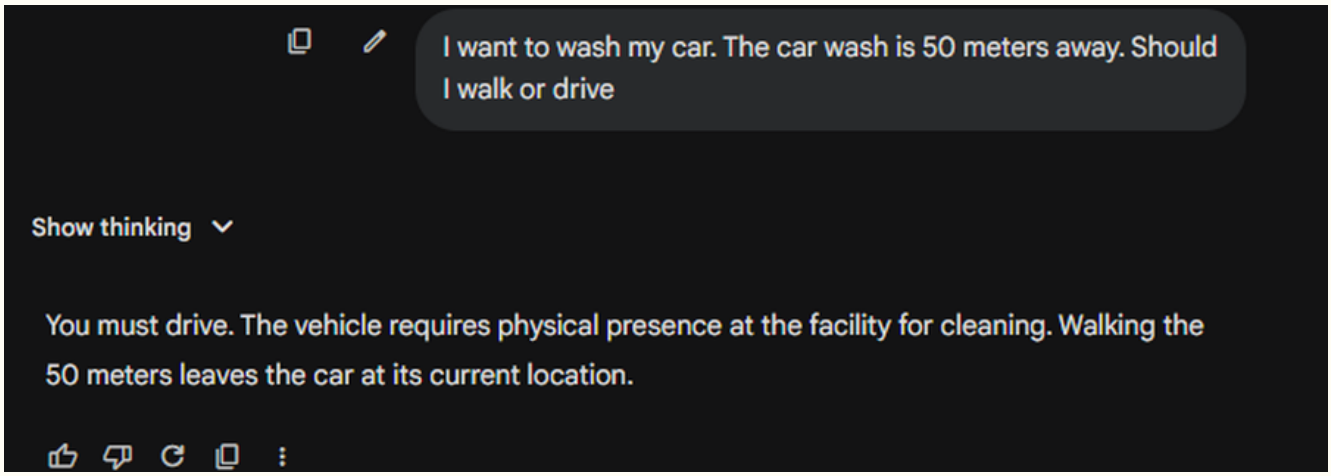
Just grab your keys/wallet/phone (whatever you need) and walk. Your car will thank you, your wallet will thank you, and the planet will thank you. Plus you get a few steps in before it gets a nice bath.

If it's pouring rain or you have some heavy stuff to carry, *then* maybe drive. Otherwise, walking wins by a mile (or in this case, by 50 meters). Enjoy the fresh air! 🚶

VERDICT

Personality did not make it correct.

Gemini 2.5 Pro parsed the goal.



VERDICT

The shortest answer happened to be correct.

THE CATCH

Walking 50 meters does not wash your car.

WHY THIS IS A TRICK

The goal in the prompt is to wash a vehicle. That vehicle is not at the car wash. If you walk, the car stays in the driveway.

THE SPLIT

Four tools answered the verbs. One reasoned about the noun.

THE PATTERN

The prompt looks like a commute question.

What the models saw

The prompt contains two transport verbs, a short distance, and a preference to make. That is the shape of a commute question.

What Gemini saw

The goal was cleaning a car. The car had to be at the car wash. Walking there leaves it at home.

BROADER FAILURE

Coding agents miss the same way when they misread a spec.

Reasoning beats fluency.

Four tools pattern-matched on walk versus drive. Only one parsed the goal.
The shortest answer was the only correct one.
LLMs default to surface patterns when reasoning would cost more tokens.
Coding agents fail this way when they misread specs.

MILIND NAIR